

New York City Travel Guide

Quick Facts

- **Country:** United States of America
- **Language:** English (over 200 languages spoken, Spanish widely used)
- **Currency:** United States Dollar (USD, \$)
- **Time Zone:** Eastern Standard Time (EST, UTC-5), EDT in summer (UTC-4)
- **Emergency Number:** 911 (police, fire, ambulance)
- **Dialing Code:** +1
- **Nicknames:** The Big Apple, The City That Never Sleeps

Visa Requirements

Visa Waiver Program (VWP)

Citizens of 41 countries can visit the USA visa-free for tourism for up to 90 days.

ESTA (Electronic System for Travel Authorization)

- **Required For:** All VWP country citizens (includes UK, EU, Japan, Australia, etc.)
- **Cost:** \$21 (valid 2 years or until passport expires)
- **Application:** Apply online at <https://esta.cbp.dhs.gov> (72 hours before travel recommended)
- **Duration:** 90 days maximum (no extensions)
- **Purpose:** Tourism, business meetings, transit only

Countries in VWP (Selected)

- **Europe:** UK, Ireland, France, Germany, Italy, Spain, Netherlands, Switzerland, Norway, Sweden
- **Asia:** Japan, South Korea, Singapore, Taiwan, Brunei
- **Oceania:** Australia, New Zealand
- **Americas:** Chile

Tourist Visa (B-2)

Required for citizens of countries NOT in VWP program.

- **Application:** Through US embassy/consulate in home country
- **Interview:** Required at embassy
- **Processing:** 3-5 weeks minimum (apply early)
- **Duration:** Up to 6 months (determined by immigration officer)
- **Cost:** \$185 application fee

Entry Requirements

- Valid passport (must be valid for at least 6 months beyond stay)
- Return or onward ticket
- Proof of sufficient funds
- ESTA or valid visa
- Customs declaration form (completed on flight)

Important Notes

- 90-day ESTA stays cannot be extended (must leave and re-apply)
- Working on ESTA/B-2 visa is illegal (deportation risk)
- Canadian and Mexican citizens have different entry rules
- Border protection officers have final say on entry

Best Time to Visit

Spring (March - May)

- **Weather:** 8-20°C (46-68°F), gradually warming, occasional rain
- **Highlights:** Cherry blossoms (Central Park, Brooklyn Botanic Garden), spring events
- **Crowds:** Moderate, increasing in May
- **Events:** St. Patrick's Day Parade (March), Tribeca Film Festival (April)
- **Pros:** Pleasant weather, flowers blooming, outdoor activities resume, mild temperatures
- **Cons:** April rain showers, spring break crowds, warming up slowly

Summer (June - August)

- **Weather:** 22-30°C (72-86°F), hot and humid
- **Highlights:** Rooftop bars, outdoor concerts, beach access (Coney Island, Rockaway)
- **Crowds:** Very high (peak tourist season)
- **Events:** Pride Parade (June), Fourth of July fireworks, SummerStage concerts, US Open (August)
- **Pros:** Long daylight hours, vibrant energy, outdoor events, full restaurant/bar patios
- **Cons:** Very hot and humid, expensive hotels, crowded attractions, occasional thunderstorms

Fall (September - November)

- **Weather:** 10-22°C (50-72°F), comfortable and crisp
- **Highlights:** Autumn foliage (Central Park peak mid-late October), comfortable exploring
- **Crowds:** Moderate to high
- **Events:** New York Fashion Week (September), Halloween Parade (October), Macy's Thanksgiving Parade (November)
- **Pros:** Best weather of year, beautiful fall colors, fewer crowds than summer, cultural events
- **Cons:** Hotel prices high in October, early winter chill in November

Winter (December - February)

- **Weather:** -1 to 5°C (30-41°F), cold with occasional snow
- **Highlights:** Holiday decorations, Rockefeller tree, ice skating, winter sales
- **Crowds:** High in December (holidays), low January-February
- **Events:** New Year's Eve (Times Square), Chinese New Year, Holiday markets
- **Pros:** Festive atmosphere (December), lowest hotel prices (January-February), winter activities, no crowds
- **Cons:** Very cold, windy, snow/slush, short daylight hours (sunset ~4:30pm)

Recommended Visit: September-October (ideal weather) or April-May (spring beauty, decent weather).

Best Value: January-February (lowest prices, but cold).

Top Attractions

Attraction	Borough/ Neighborhood	Entry Fee	Hours	Best Time to Visit
Statue of Liberty & Ellis Island	New York Harbor	\$24-30 (ferry+audio)	9:30-17:00	Weekday morning, book weeks ahead
Empire State Building	Midtown Manhattan	\$44-79	9:00-midnight	Sunset or night, buy skip-the-line
Central Park	Manhattan (UWS/UES)	Free	6:00-1:00am	Morning or fall foliage season
Times Square	Midtown Manhattan	Free	24/7	Evening for lights, avoid New Year's Eve
Brooklyn Bridge	Manhattan/ Brooklyn	Free	24/7 (walkway)	Early morning or sunset (less crowded)
Metropolitan Museum of Art	Upper East Side	\$30 (suggested donation)	10:00-17:00 (closed Mon)	Friday/Saturday late hours, weekdays
9/11 Memorial & Museum	Financial District	Free (memorial), \$29 (museum)	9:00-20:00	Morning on weekdays, emotional experience
High Line	Chelsea/West Side	Free	7:00-22:00	Sunset, spring/summer for greenery
Museum of Modern Art (MoMA)	Midtown Manhattan	\$30	10:30-17:30	Friday evening (free 16:00-20:00), weekdays
Grand Central Terminal	Midtown Manhattan	Free	5:30-2:00am	Midday (light through windows), rush hour

Additional Must-See Attractions

- **Rockefeller Center:** Observation deck (Top of the Rock, \$40), ice skating (seasonal, \$33)
- **One World Observatory:** Views from tallest building in Western Hemisphere (\$44)
- **Brooklyn Botanic Garden:** Beautiful gardens, cherry blossoms (seasonal, \$18)
- **Coney Island:** Beach, boardwalk, amusement park (summer, free/rides vary)
- **Chelsea Market:** Food hall in converted factory (free, food costs)
- **The Vessel (Hudson Yards):** Sculpture and viewpoint (free with reservation)

Iconic Neighborhoods to Explore

- **Greenwich Village:** Historic streets, Washington Square Park, independent shops
- **SoHo:** Cast-iron architecture, boutique shopping, art galleries
- **Lower East Side:** Tenement history, street art, trendy bars
- **Williamsburg (Brooklyn):** Hipster culture, indie shops, waterfront parks

Boroughs and Neighborhoods

Manhattan

Midtown

- **Character:** Commercial heart, skyscrapers, Broadway theaters, major tourist sites
- **Must-See:** Times Square, Empire State Building, Rockefeller Center, Grand Central, Bryant Park
- **Food:** Tourist restaurants (pricey), chain dining, theater district pre-show dining
- **Transport:** Times Square-42nd St, Grand Central (multiple subway lines)
- **Best For:** Iconic NYC experience, Broadway shows, major landmarks, first-time visitors

Lower Manhattan/Financial District

- **Character:** Historic downtown, Wall Street, waterfront, 9/11 site
- **Must-See:** 9/11 Memorial, Statue of Liberty ferry, Wall Street, Battery Park
- **Food:** Financial district lunch spots, upscale dining, historic taverns
- **Transport:** Fulton St, Wall St, Cortlandt St (multiple lines)
- **Best For:** American history, ferry access, finance industry, 9/11 memorial

Greenwich Village & West Village

- **Character:** Bohemian history, tree-lined streets, Washington Square Park
- **Must-See:** Washington Square Park, Stonewall Inn, comedy clubs, independent shops
- **Food:** Diverse restaurants, historic cafes, pizza (Joe's Pizza, John's), Italian
- **Transport:** W 4th St, Christopher St (1, 2, A, C, E lines)
- **Best For:** Cafe culture, nightlife, LGBTQ+ history, charming streets

SoHo (South of Houston)

- **Character:** Cast-iron architecture, high-end shopping, art galleries
- **Must-See:** Cobblestone streets, designer boutiques, street art, gallery hopping
- **Food:** Trendy restaurants, brunch spots, bakeries
- **Transport:** Spring St, Prince St (N, R, W, 6 lines)
- **Best For:** Shopping, architecture, art scene, Instagram-worthy streets

Upper West Side

- **Character:** Residential elegance, cultural institutions, family-friendly
- **Must-See:** Lincoln Center, American Museum of Natural History, Central Park West
- **Food:** Classic NYC delis, neighborhood bistros, bagel shops
- **Transport:** 72nd St, 81st St, 96th St (1, 2, 3 lines)
- **Best For:** Museums, residential vibe, Central Park access, upper-class NYC life

Upper East Side

- **Character:** Wealthy residential, Museum Mile, elegant townhouses
- **Must-See:** Metropolitan Museum of Art, Guggenheim, Central Park East, Madison Avenue shopping
- **Food:** High-end restaurants, classic diners, European cafes
- **Transport:** 77th St, 86th St, Lexington Av (4, 5, 6 lines)
- **Best For:** World-class museums, upscale shopping, classic NYC wealth

Brooklyn

Williamsburg

- **Character:** Hipster central, indie culture, waterfront parks
- **Must-See:** Bedford Avenue, East River State Park, Smorgasburg (weekend food market)
- **Food:** Farm-to-table restaurants, craft breweries, artisanal everything
- **Transport:** Bedford Av, Lorimer St (L line)
- **Best For:** Young crowd, nightlife, indie music, vintage shopping, waterfront views

DUMBO (Down Under Manhattan Bridge Overpass)

- **Character:** Converted warehouses, tech offices, stunning Manhattan views
- **Must-See:** Brooklyn Bridge Park, Manhattan Bridge photo spot, Jane's Carousel

- **Food:** Trendy restaurants, Grimaldi's pizza, Time Out Market
- **Transport:** York St (F line), High St-Brooklyn Bridge (A, C lines)
- **Best For:** Photography, waterfront walks, iconic NYC views, weekend outing

Park Slope

- **Character:** Family-friendly, brownstone-lined streets, progressive community
- **Must-See:** Prospect Park, Brooklyn Public Library, historic brownstones
- **Food:** Neighborhood restaurants, cafes, farmer's market
- **Transport:** Grand Army Plaza, 7th Av (2, 3, B, Q lines)
- **Best For:** Residential Brooklyn life, families, parks

Food & Dining

Iconic New York Foods

Pizza

- **New York Style:** Large, thin, foldable slices
- **Price:** \$3-5 per slice, \$15-25 whole pie
- **Classic Spots:** Joe's Pizza (Greenwich Village), Prince Street Pizza, Di Fara (Brooklyn)
- **Rule:** Fold the slice lengthwise, eat standing or walking

Bagels

- **Real Deal:** Boiled then baked, chewy inside, crispy outside
- **Price:** \$2-4 plain, \$8-12 with lox and cream cheese
- **Classic Spots:** Russ & Daughters, Ess-a-Bagel, Murray's Bagels
- **Order:** "Schmear" = cream cheese, "lox" = smoked salmon

Hot Dogs

- **Street Carts:** Classic NYC street food (\$2-3)
- **Nathan's Famous:** Original Coney Island location
- **Toppings:** Mustard, sauerkraut, onions (never ketchup, according to purists)

Deli Sandwiches

- **Pastrami on Rye:** Classic Jewish deli sandwich (\$18-25)

- **Famous Delis:** Katz's Delicatessen, Russ & Daughters, Barney Greengrass
- **Order:** Hot pastrami on rye with mustard (traditional)

Diverse International Cuisine

- **Chinatown:** Dim sum, Peking duck, hand-pulled noodles (\$8-20/person)
- **Little Italy:** Classic Italian-American red sauce joints (\$15-30/person)
- **Koreatown (32nd St):** Korean BBQ, bibimbap, all-night restaurants (\$20-40/person)
- **Jackson Heights (Queens):** Most diverse food neighborhood (Indian, Colombian, Thai, etc.)

Food Culture

Brunch

- **NYC Institution:** Weekend brunch is religion (10:00-15:00, expect waits)
- **Price:** \$15-30/person
- **Classic Dishes:** Eggs Benedict, pancakes, avocado toast, bottomless mimosas
- **Popular Spots:** Clinton St. Baking Company, Jack's Wife Freda, Balthazar

Food Trucks and Street Carts

- **Halal Carts:** Chicken/lamb over rice with white/hot sauce (\$8-10)
- **Food Trucks:** Gourmet options (tacos, lobster rolls, waffles, \$10-15)
- **Coffee Carts:** \$1.50 "coffee regular" (coffee with milk and sugar)

Dining Etiquette and Tipping

- **Tipping:** 18-20% standard for sit-down restaurants (calculated pre-tax)
- **Tipping Calculation:** Double the tax (8.875%) for ~18%
- **Fast Casual:** Tip jars common, \$1-2 or 10% optional
- **Delivery:** 15-20% tip plus \$2-3 for delivery
- **No Loitering:** Tables turned quickly, especially at peak hours

Price Ranges

- **Budget (\$8-15/meal):** Pizza slices, bagels, food carts, food halls, fast casual
- **Mid-Range (\$20-40/meal):** Casual restaurants, brunch spots, ethnic cuisine, neighborhood joints
- **High-End (\$60-150+/meal):** Fine dining, tasting menus, Michelin-starred, steak houses

Reservations

- **Weekend Dinner:** Book 1-4 weeks ahead for popular restaurants
- **Apps:** Resy, OpenTable (most common), some restaurants only take phone reservations
- **Walk-Ins:** Bar seating often first-come, or visit off-peak hours (before 6pm, after 9pm)

Transportation

From Airports

John F. Kennedy International Airport (JFK)

- **Location:** 24 km southeast of Manhattan (45-75 minutes to Midtown)
- **AirTrain + Subway:** AirTrain to Jamaica/Howard Beach (\$8.25) + Subway to Manhattan (\$2.90) = \$11.15 total (slowest, cheapest, 75-90 min)
- **AirTrain + LIRR:** AirTrain to Jamaica (\$8.25) + LIRR train to Penn Station (\$10.25-15) = ~\$19-23 (faster, 50-60 min)
- **Express Bus:** NYC Airporter to Grand Central/Port Authority (\$19-29, 60-90 min)
- **Taxi (Yellow Cab):** Flat rate \$70 to Manhattan + tolls + tip = ~\$85-95 (45-75 min depending on traffic)
- **Uber/Lyft:** \$60-100 depending on time and surge pricing
- **Private Car:** Pre-booked services (\$80-120)

LaGuardia Airport (LGA)

- **Location:** 13 km east of Manhattan (30-60 minutes to Midtown)
- **Bus + Subway:** M60 SBS bus to 125th St (\$2.90), connect to subway (cheap, 60-90 min)
- **Express Bus:** NYC Airporter (\$16-19, 45-60 min)
- **Taxi:** Metered fare, ~\$35-50 + tolls + tip = \$45-65
- **Uber/Lyft:** \$40-70 depending on time

Newark Liberty International Airport (EWR)

- **Location:** 24 km west in New Jersey (45-75 minutes to Midtown)
- **AirTrain + NJ Transit:** AirTrain to Newark Airport station (\$8.25) + NJ Transit train to Penn Station (\$15.25) = \$23.50 (60-75 min)
- **Express Bus:** Newark Airport Express to Grand Central/Port Authority (\$19-31, 45-75 min)
- **Taxi:** Metered fare ~\$60-80 + tolls + tip = \$80-100

- **Uber/Lyft:** \$60-100 (tolls included)

Subway (MTA)

System Overview

- **Lines:** 27 subway lines (letters and numbers), 472 stations
- **Coverage:** Comprehensive in Manhattan, Brooklyn, Queens; limited in Bronx; none in Staten Island
- **Hours:** 24/7 service (some lines limited overnight)
- **Frequency:** Every 3-10 minutes peak hours, 10-20 minutes overnight

Fares and Passes

- **Single Ride:** \$2.90 per trip (regardless of distance, transfers allowed within 2 hours)
- **MetroCard:** Reloadable card (\$1 new card fee)
- **Unlimited Ride:** 7-day (\$34) or 30-day (\$132) - pays for itself at 12 trips/week or 47 trips/month
- **OMNY:** Tap-to-pay with contactless card/phone (same pricing, automatic fare capping)
- **Senior/Disabled:** Reduced fare (\$1.45) with qualifying MetroCard

Navigation Tips

- **Uptown/Downtown:** Uptown = northbound (higher street numbers), Downtown = southbound (lower numbers)
- **Express vs Local:** Express trains skip stops (look for white circle vs black on map)
- **Transfers:** Free between subway lines within 2 hours (must use same MetroCard/OMNY)
- **Weekend Changes:** Service changes common on weekends (check MTA website or app)
- **Safety:** Generally safe 24/7, stay in lit areas, middle cars often safer late night

Apps

- **Citymapper:** Best for real-time directions and alternative routes
- **Google Maps:** Accurate subway directions and live updates
- **MTA App:** Official app with service status and trip planner

Buses

- **Fare:** Same as subway (\$2.90, free transfer within 2 hours)
- **Routes:** Extensive, but slower than subway due to traffic

- **Select Bus Service (SBS):** Limited-stop express routes on major avenues
- **Payment:** MetroCard, OMNY, or exact change (coins only, no bills)

Taxis and Rideshare

Yellow Cabs (Iconic NYC Taxis)

- **Availability:** Only allowed to pick up street hails in Manhattan/airports
- **Fare:** \$3 initial + \$0.70 per 1/5 mile or 60 seconds + \$0.50 MTA tax + tolls
- **Tip:** 15-20% (add to credit card payment in backseat screen)
- **Average Ride:** \$15-25 for typical Manhattan trip
- **Hailing:** Raise arm when medallion light is on (off = occupied)

Green Cabs (Boro Taxis)

- **Service Area:** Outer boroughs and upper Manhattan (above 96th St)
- **Same Fares:** As yellow cabs
- **Purpose:** Serve areas yellow cabs rarely go

Uber/Lyft

- **Availability:** Excellent throughout all boroughs
- **Pricing:** Varies with demand (surge pricing during rush hour, bad weather, events)
- **Typical:** \$15-30 for most Manhattan trips (non-surge)
- **Airport:** Pre-book for pickup (designated zones at airports)
- **UberPool/Lyft Shared:** Cheaper option, share ride with others

Walking

- **Grid System:** Manhattan streets numbered, easy navigation (avenues run north-south, streets east-west)
- **Distances:** Avenue blocks ~260m (3 min walk), street blocks ~80m (1 min walk)
- **Walkability:** Manhattan very walkable, Brooklyn neighborhoods too
- **Safety:** Use crosswalks, pedestrian signals (jaywalking common but technically illegal)

Citi Bike (Bike Share)

- **Stations:** 1,000+ stations in Manhattan, Brooklyn, Queens
- **Cost:** \$4.79 for single 30-min ride, \$19.95/day pass, \$219/year membership

- **Usage:** Unlock with app or credit card at kiosk, must dock within 30/45 min to avoid fees
- **Bike Lanes:** Improving network, but share road carefully
- **Helmet:** Not provided (bring your own or skip)

Cultural Tips & Customs

Communication Style

- **Direct:** New Yorkers are blunt and to-the-point (not rude, just efficient)
- **Fast-Paced:** Fast walking, fast talking, don't block sidewalks
- **Friendly:** Despite reputation, most New Yorkers helpful if you ask
- **Eye Contact:** Normal and expected, not considered aggressive

Social Etiquette

- **Personal Space:** Limited in crowded subway, but respected when possible
- **Lines/Queues:** Form orderly lines, cutting is serious offense
- **Sidewalk Rules:** Walk on right, pass on left, don't stop suddenly
- **Subway Etiquette:** Let passengers off before boarding, move into car, backpacks on floor
- **Don't:** Block subway doors, stop at top of stairs, walk slowly in middle of sidewalk

Tipping Culture (Essential!)

- **Restaurants:** 18-20% of pre-tax bill (MANDATORY, not optional)
- **Bars:** \$1-2 per drink or 15-20% on tab
- **Taxis/Uber:** 15-20%
- **Hotels:** \$2-5 per bag (bellhop), \$5-10/day (housekeeping, leave daily)
- **Hair Salon:** 15-20%
- **Delivery:** 15-20% + \$2-3 minimum
- **Coffee Shop:** \$1 or spare change in tip jar (optional)

Diversity and Respect

- **Multicultural:** Over 800 languages spoken, every culture represented
- **Respect:** Be open-minded, respectful of all backgrounds
- **Neighborhoods:** Each has distinct cultural identity, embrace it
- **LGBTQ+ Friendly:** Very accepting, especially in Manhattan

"New York Minute"

- **Meaning:** Everything moves fast - walking, talking, eating, working
- **Don't:** Stand still in middle of sidewalk, walk slowly in commuter areas
- **Do:** Walk with purpose, be aware of surroundings, keep pace

Safety & Health

General Safety

- **Crime:** Safer than ever, one of safest large US cities
- **Tourist Areas:** Generally very safe day and night
- **Subway:** Safe 24/7, stay in occupied cars late night, middle cars often safest
- **Awareness:** Standard urban awareness (watch belongings, avoid empty streets late night)
- **Scams:** Costumed characters in Times Square demand tips (don't engage if you don't want photo)

Specific Safety Tips

- **Times Square:** Watch for aggressive panhandlers, ticket scammers (buy theater tickets at official TKTS booth)
- **Subway:** Keep bags zipped, phone secure, don't fall asleep
- **Pedestrian Safety:** Look both ways (bikes, cars, buses, don't assume right of way)
- **Neighborhoods:** Almost all neighborhoods safe, use common sense late night

Emergency Services

- **Universal Emergency:** 911 (police, fire, ambulance)
- **Non-Emergency Police:** 311
- **Hospitals:** Excellent healthcare, but VERY expensive without insurance
- **Travel Insurance:** Essential for international visitors (healthcare costs \$1000s)

Healthcare

- **Emergency Rooms:** Required to treat regardless of insurance (but will bill)
- **Urgent Care:** Walk-in clinics for non-emergencies (CityMD, ProHEALTH, etc.)
- **Pharmacies:** CVS, Walgreens, Duane Reade (24-hour locations available)
- **Prescriptions:** Bring sufficient medication, refilling prescriptions difficult for visitors

Practical Information

Electricity and Adapters

- **Voltage:** 120V
- **Frequency:** 60Hz
- **Plug Type:** Type A and B (two/three flat prongs)
- **Adapters:** European/Asian visitors need adapters (buy at airport, Best Buy, or Amazon)

Internet and WiFi

- **Public WiFi:** LinkNYC kiosks throughout city (free, fast WiFi)
- **Cafes/Restaurants:** Free WiFi almost everywhere (ask for password)
- **Subway:** Limited WiFi in some stations (not in tunnels)
- **SIM Cards:** T-Mobile, AT&T prepaid SIMs at airports/stores (\$30-50 for 7-30 days)
- **Coverage:** Excellent 4G/5G throughout all boroughs

Money and Currency

- **Cash:** Less common, cards accepted almost everywhere
- **Credit Cards:** Universally accepted (Visa, Mastercard, Amex, Discover)
- **Chip and Signature:** Chip cards standard, signature usually required (PIN optional)
- **ATMs:** Abundant, \$3-5 fee for out-of-network withdrawals
- **Tipping Cash:** Keep \$1 and \$5 bills for tips
- **Contactless:** Apple Pay, Google Pay widely accepted

Sales Tax

- **Rate:** 8.875% added at checkout (not included in displayed prices)
- **Applies To:** Most goods and services (clothing under \$110 exempt)
- **Restaurant Bills:** Tax ~8.875%, tip 18-20% calculated on pre-tax amount

Business Hours

- **Shops:** Generally 10:00-20:00 or 21:00 (many open Sundays)
- **Restaurants:** Varies widely, many open late (especially diners - 24/7)
- **Museums:** Usually 10:00-17:00 or 18:00 (check specific museum, many closed Mondays)
- **Grocery:** Delis and bodegas often 24/7, supermarkets 7:00-23:00 or 24/7

Useful Apps

- **Citymapper:** Best navigation app for NYC (subway, bus, walking, biking)
- **Resy/OpenTable:** Restaurant reservations
- **Yelp:** Restaurant/business reviews and recommendations
- **TodayTix:** Last-minute Broadway ticket discounts
- **Seamless/UberEats:** Food delivery
- **Meetup:** Find local events and groups

Public Holidays

- **New Year's Day:** January 1
- **Martin Luther King Jr. Day:** Third Monday in January
- **Presidents' Day:** Third Monday in February
- **Memorial Day:** Last Monday in May
- **Independence Day:** July 4
- **Labor Day:** First Monday in September
- **Thanksgiving:** Fourth Thursday in November (major holiday, many businesses closed)
- **Christmas:** December 25

Weather Preparedness

- **Summer:** Sunscreen, water bottle, light clothes (indoor AC very cold - bring layer)
- **Winter:** Warm coat, layers, hat, gloves, waterproof boots (heated indoors = peel layers)
- **Rain:** Umbrella essential year-round (sold at every corner bodega during rain)
- **Snow:** Can be significant (Dec-March), sidewalks cleared quickly

Budget Guide

Daily Budget Estimates

Budget Traveler (\$100-150/day): - Accommodation: Hostel or budget hotel (\$40-80) - Meals: Pizza, food carts, delis, no sit-down restaurants (\$30-40) - Transport: 7-day MetroCard (\$34 for week, \$5/day averaged) - Activities: Free attractions, one paid museum with donation (\$10-20)

Mid-Range Traveler (\$250-400/day): - Accommodation: Mid-range hotel or Airbnb (\$150-250) - Meals: Breakfast bagel, lunch casual, dinner restaurant (\$60-100) - Transport: MetroCard + occasional Uber (\$15-25) - Activities: Museums, attractions, Broadway show once (\$50-100)

Luxury Traveler (\$600+/day): - Accommodation: 4-5 star hotel (\$400-800+) - Meals: Fine dining, Michelin restaurants, cocktails (\$200-400+) - Transport: Uber/taxis (\$30-60) - Activities: Premium shows, private tours, exclusive experiences (\$100-200+)

Money-Saving Tips

1. **Museum Donations:** Many museums "suggested admission" (you can pay less, but discouraged)
2. **Free Fridays:** MoMA free Fridays 16:00-20:00 (very crowded)
3. **TKTS Booth:** Same-day Broadway tickets 20-50% off (Times Square, South Street Seaport)
4. **Happy Hours:** 17:00-19:00 drink and appetizer specials
5. **Walking:** Manhattan is walkable, save subway fares
6. **Pizza/Bagels:** Cheap, filling, authentic NYC experience
7. **Unlimited MetroCard:** Pays for itself at 12+ rides in 7 days
8. **Free Attractions:** Central Park, Brooklyn Bridge, High Line, Staten Island Ferry (free, views of Statue)

Final Tips

1. **Walk Like You Know Where You're Going:** Even if lost, step aside to check map
2. **Download Offline Maps:** For subway outages or low battery
3. **Keep Right:** On sidewalks, escalators, stairs
4. **Don't Look Up:** Tourists look up at buildings (but do it off to side)
5. **Bodega = Corner Store:** Buy water, snacks, umbrellas, coffee (cheaper than Starbucks)
6. **"Waiting on Line" not "In Line":** NY English quirk
7. **Coffee Regular:** Coffee with milk and sugar (from cart/deli)
8. **24/7 City:** Something always open, city never sleeps (literally)
9. **Jaywalking:** Locals do it, technically illegal, use judgment
10. **Embrace the Energy:** NYC thrives on hustle and diversity - lean into it

Emergency Contacts: - Emergency: 911 - Non-Emergency: 311 - Visitor Information: Times Square Visitor Center, +1-212-484-1222

New York City rewards those who dive in fearlessly - navigate the subway like a local, grab a slice at 2am, walk across the Brooklyn Bridge, and soak in the electric energy of the world's most iconic city.

Enjoy your New York adventure! Welcome to the Big Apple!